UX/UI CASE STUDY

Bondly

New people. Real plans.

A mobile app for small-group meetups that can turn into ongoing groups. Researched, designed and tested from scratch.

Agostina Boris · Research, product concept and UX/UI design · 2026

Try the prototype →



CONTEXT · THE PROBLEM

Wanting to meet new people isn't the same as meeting them

WHERE IT STARTED

In the meetup groups I'm part of, the same people kept going to the same places. I wanted to find out whether that was a real gap or just my own experience.

RESEARCH QUESTION

When do existing groups and tools help people meet someone new, and when do they fall short?

CONTEXT · GOAL AND ROLE

From a first meetup to an ongoing group

My role

Solo project: UX research, product concept, UX/UI design, prototyping and usability testing.

Scope

Discover a meetup, join a small group, show up, and plan the next meetup together.

Evidence

7 interviews and 2 venue conversations. A clickable prototype tested with 5 people: 4 completed the full journey.

RESEARCH · INTERVIEWS

I interviewed 7 people and 2 venues

	Who	Age	City
P01	Freelancer with an irregular social life	29	Buenos Aires
P02	Analyst with a stable but closed circle	34	Córdoba
P03	Student looking for creative spaces	24	Rosario
P04	Parent and business owner with little time	41	Montevideo
P05	Signs up, but doesn't always show	27	Buenos Aires
P06	Retiree looking for activity and company	63	La Plata
P07	Recently moved, no local network	31	Mendoza

METHOD

Semi-structured interviews about real past experiences, not opinions about a future app.

Venues: a cultural center and an outdoor activity space.

Exploratory and qualitative: not representative of all users.

Research in Argentina and Uruguay. The prototype uses Barcelona as an illustrative city; a pilot would need local validation.

RESEARCH · HOW PEOPLE DO IT TODAY

Finding company takes several tools



Discover

Instagram and local searches



Join

Meetup and Strava



Coordinate

WhatsApp and Facebook groups



Places

Cultural centers, university, retiree clubs

Close circles bring trust, but fewer chances to meet someone new.

RESEARCH · BENCHMARK

How others bring people together

	Meetup	Bumble BFF	Timeleft	Bondly
Starting point	Interest communities and events	Nearby profiles and groups	Organized meetups and an affinity quiz	Interests and small meetups nearby
Who organizes	User picks the event; a host runs it	User picks connections; groups make plans	User books; the platform assigns the group	User picks the plan; Bondly organizes and forms a small group
Lesson for Bondly	Give a concrete reason to meet	Support continuity inside the group	Remove the effort of organizing	Combine the three, and invite the same group to meet again

OPPORTUNITY · HYPOTHESIS

Choose a plan, know what to expect, and keep the connection after.

Official sources reviewed Oct 14, 2026. Desk research, not usability testing.

RESEARCH · FINDINGS

Three moments where people drop off

1 · BEFORE GOING

Doubts about the plan, tiredness, weather or fear of arriving alone can undo a sign-up.

Opportunity

Make the plan concrete and show it's happening.

2 · ON ARRIVAL

Introductions and the first silences were the hardest part. A shared activity helps.

Opportunity

Say exactly where to wait and who's already there.

3 · AFTER THE MEETUP

Contacts fade when nobody proposes the next plan. A set date, place and group chat kept it going.

Opportunity

Make suggesting a date and place the easy next step.

RESEARCH · VENUES

Hosting a group takes more than a space

	Cultural center	Outdoor space
Group size	8 to 25 people	Varies by activity
Notice	5 days	3 to 4 days
Expect organizers to handle	Sign-ups and the list	Safety, first aid, being there
Main friction	Late confirmations, disorder	Overbooking, absent organizer

HOW BONDLY ANSWERS IT

Late confirmations → a meetup is confirmed once three members join.

Absent organizer → Bondly organizes every meetup and names the exact meeting point.

Unclear expectations → the app says upfront what isn't included.

RESEARCH · THE KEY INSIGHT

Interest doesn't guarantee attendance. A good first meetup doesn't guarantee a second.

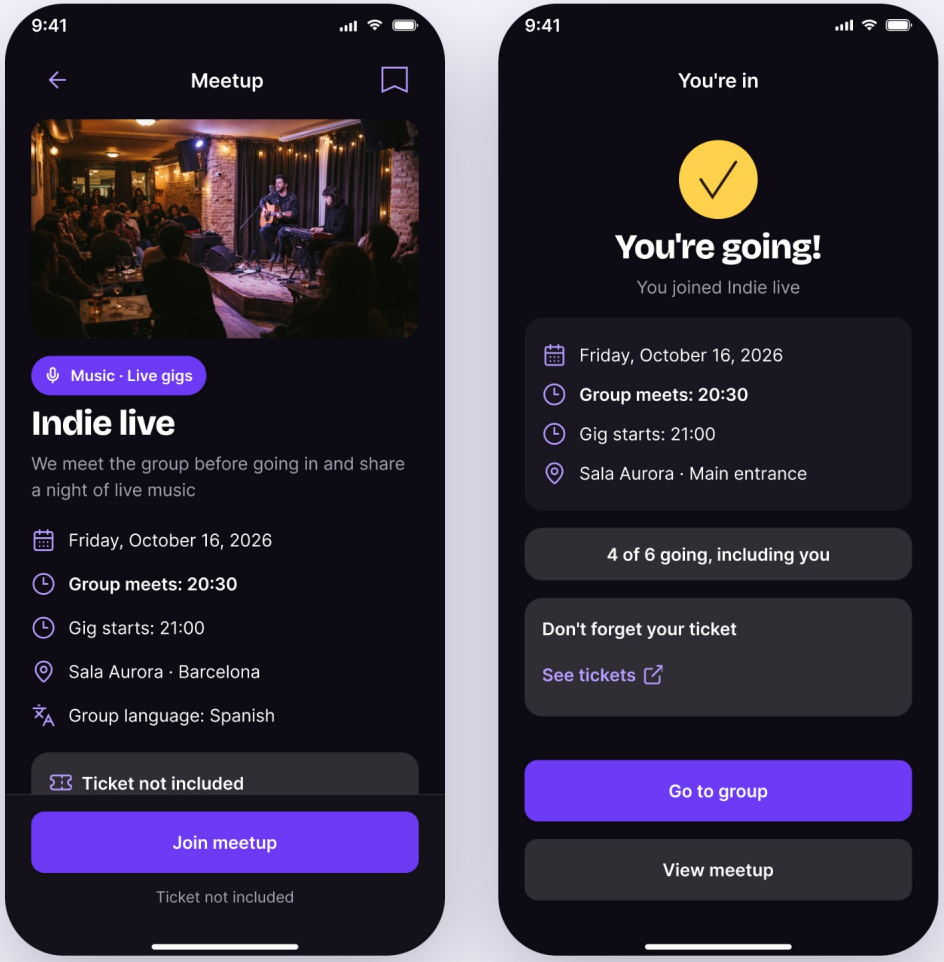
I started out designing for meeting someone new. The research moved the problem: the hard part is showing up, and then meeting again. So the design focuses on three moments: deciding to go, arriving, and planning the next meetup.

DESIGN · 1 · BEFORE GOING

Make the plan feel certain

- Separate times for when the group meets and when the activity starts.
- The exact meeting point, down to the entrance.
- Who's going, the group's language, and what isn't included.

From finding 1: doubts about the plan undo sign-ups



DESIGN · 2 · ON ARRIVAL

Nobody should have to look for strangers

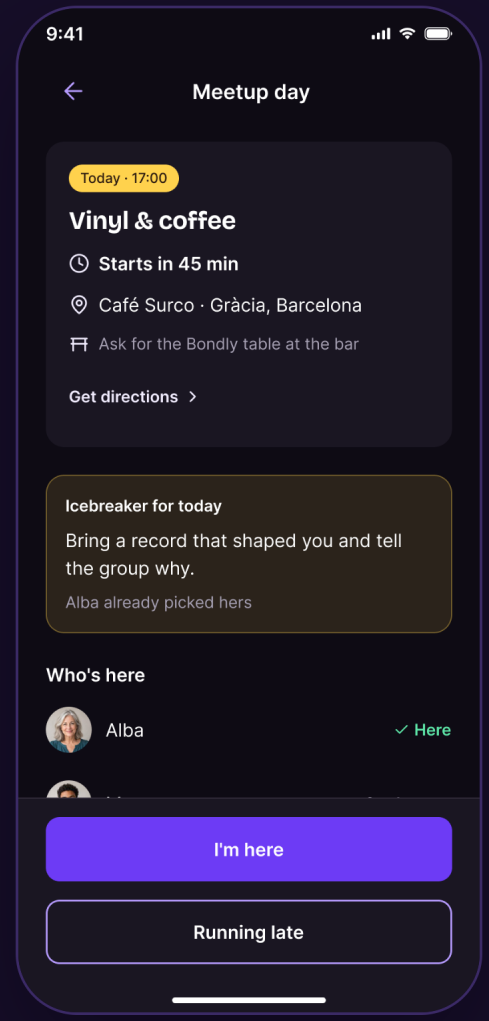
> A concrete instruction for where to go, like asking for the Bondly table at the bar.

> Who's already there, who's on the way and who's running late.

> One tap to say "I'm here" or "Running late".

> An icebreaker tied to the activity, so the first silence already has a topic.

From finding 2: the first minutes are the hardest

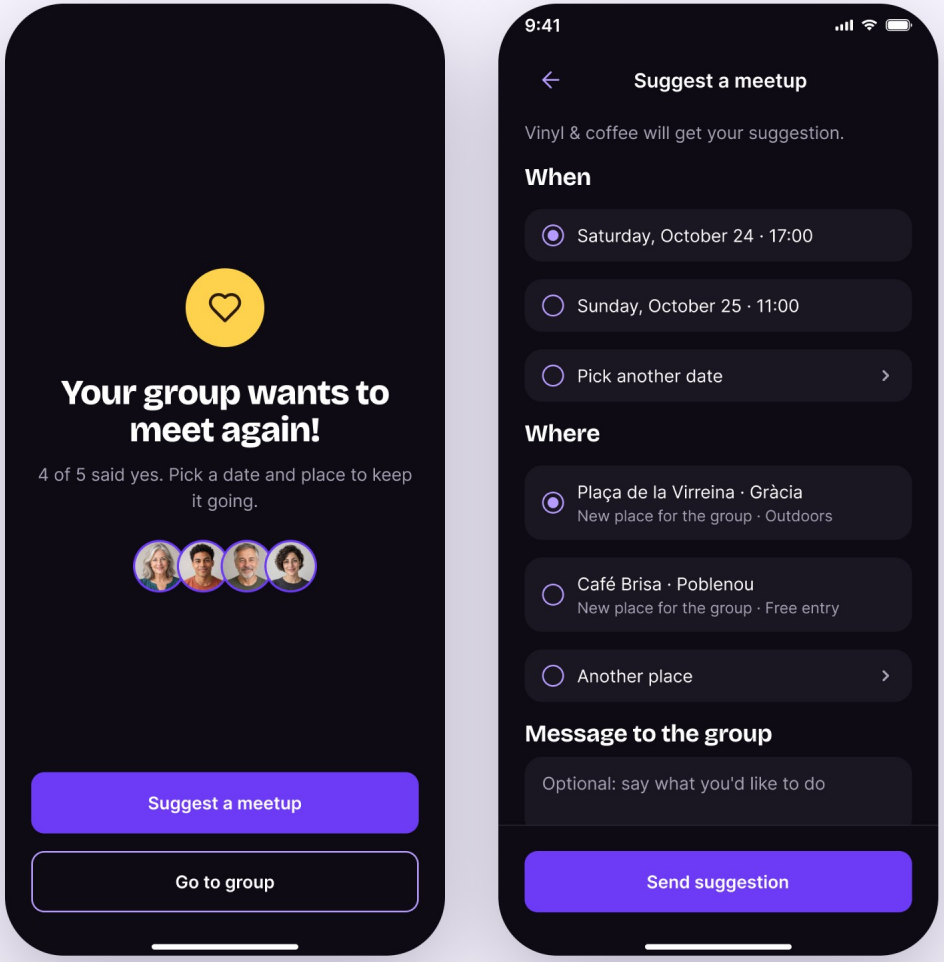


DESIGN · 3 · AFTER THE MEETUP

Make meeting again the easy next step

- The app asks if the group wants to meet again.
- Anyone can suggest a date and place, with spots the group hasn't been to flagged.
- The meetup is confirmed once three members join.

From finding 3: contacts fade without a plan



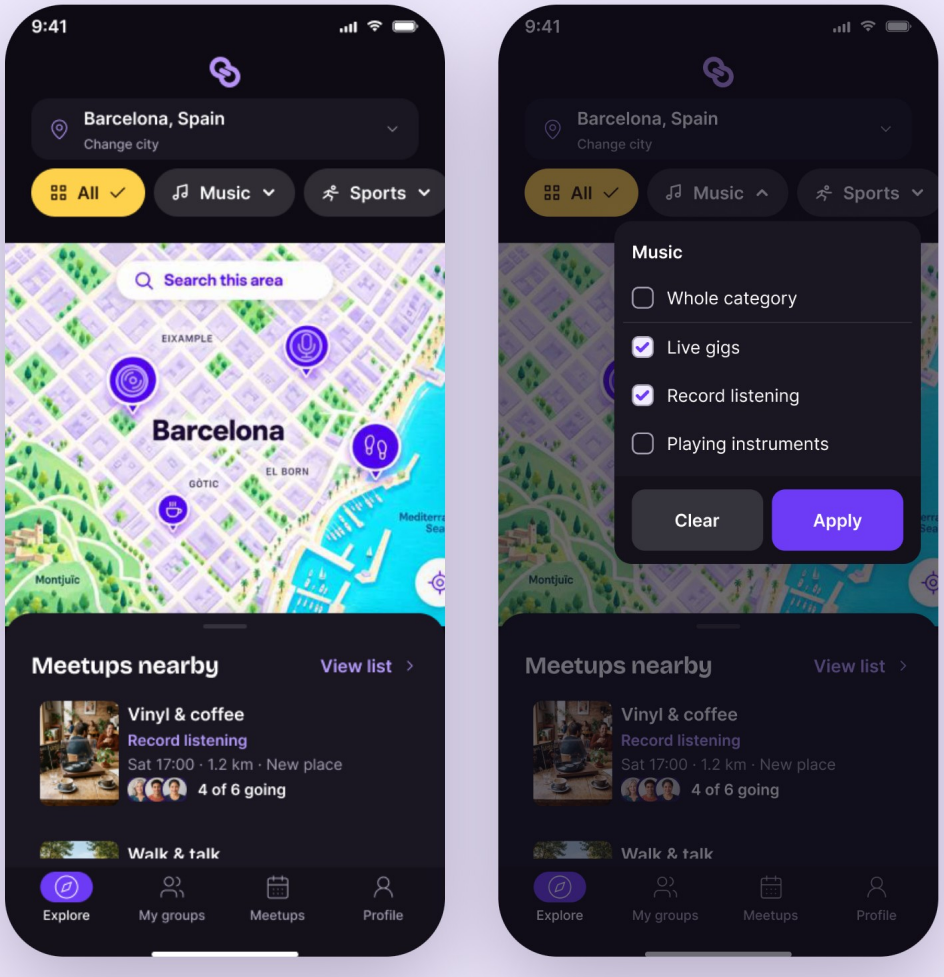
DESIGN · DISCOVERY

Something you enjoy, somewhere new

A map with nearby meetups, each tagged when it's a new place, against "always the same places".

Each interest opens its subcategories, so people narrow down without leaving the map.

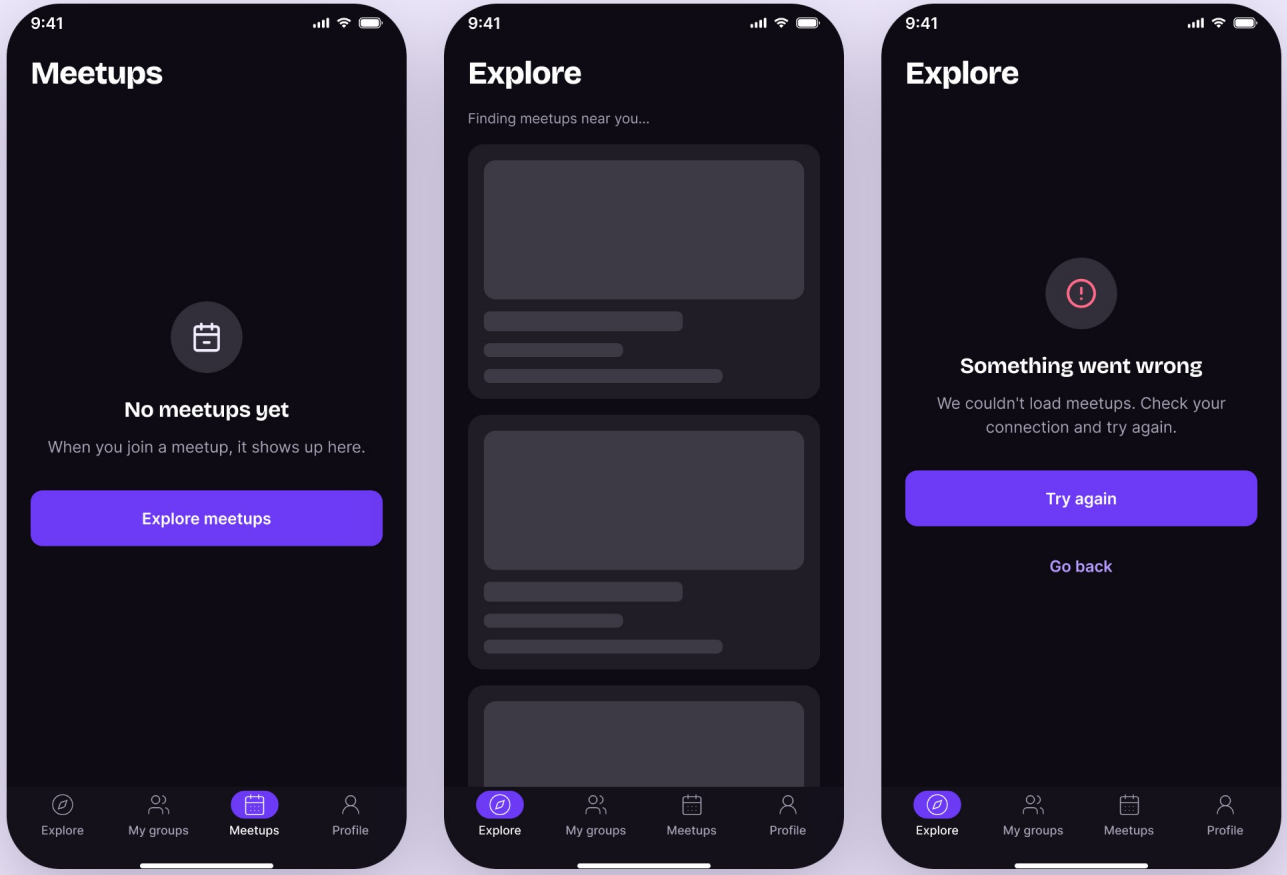
Every card shows how many people are going, so the plan looks alive before joining.



DESIGN · EDGE CASES

Every screen knows what to say when it's empty

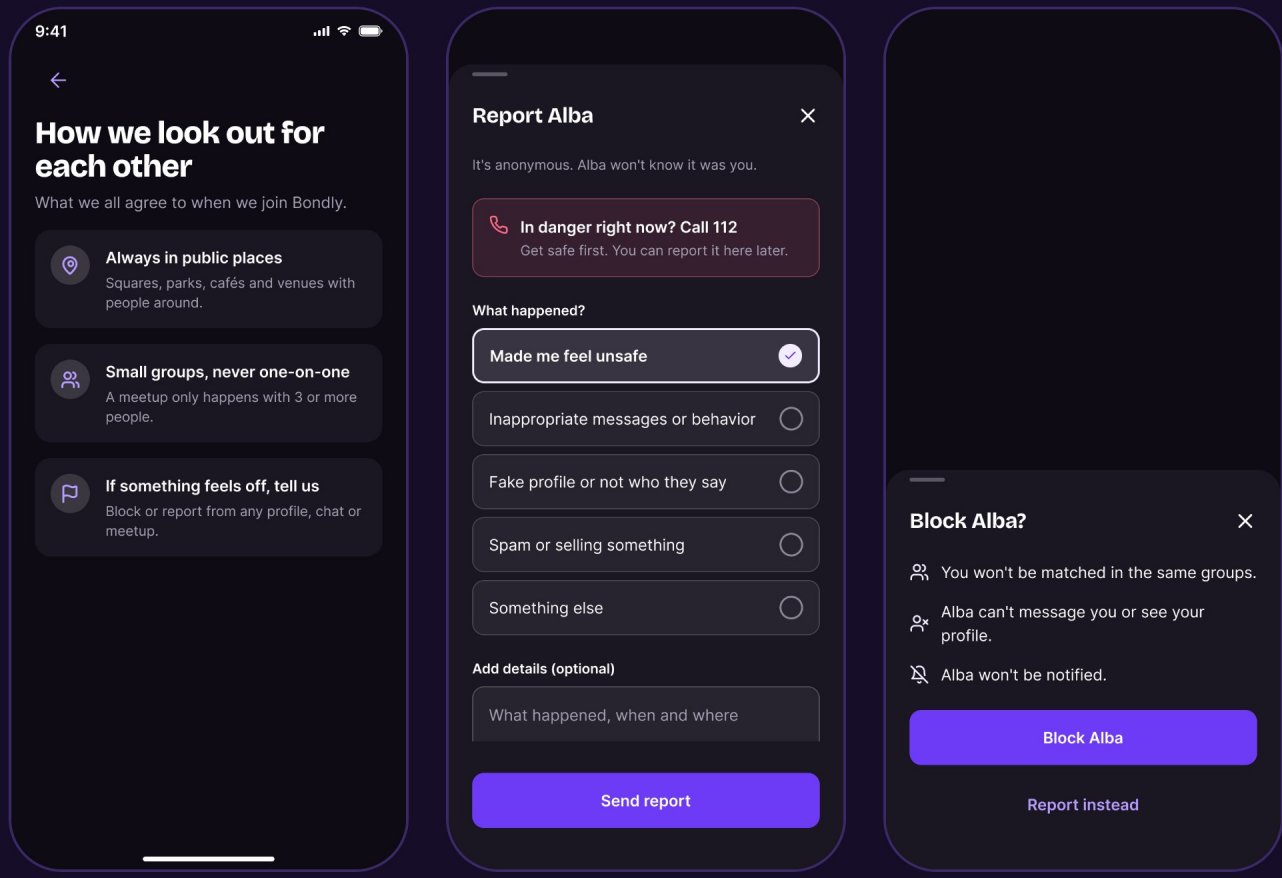
- Empty states point to the next action instead of a dead end.
- Loading keeps the layout in place, so nothing jumps.
- Errors explain what happened and offer a way out.



DESIGN · SAFETY AND TRUST

Meeting strangers needs trust built in

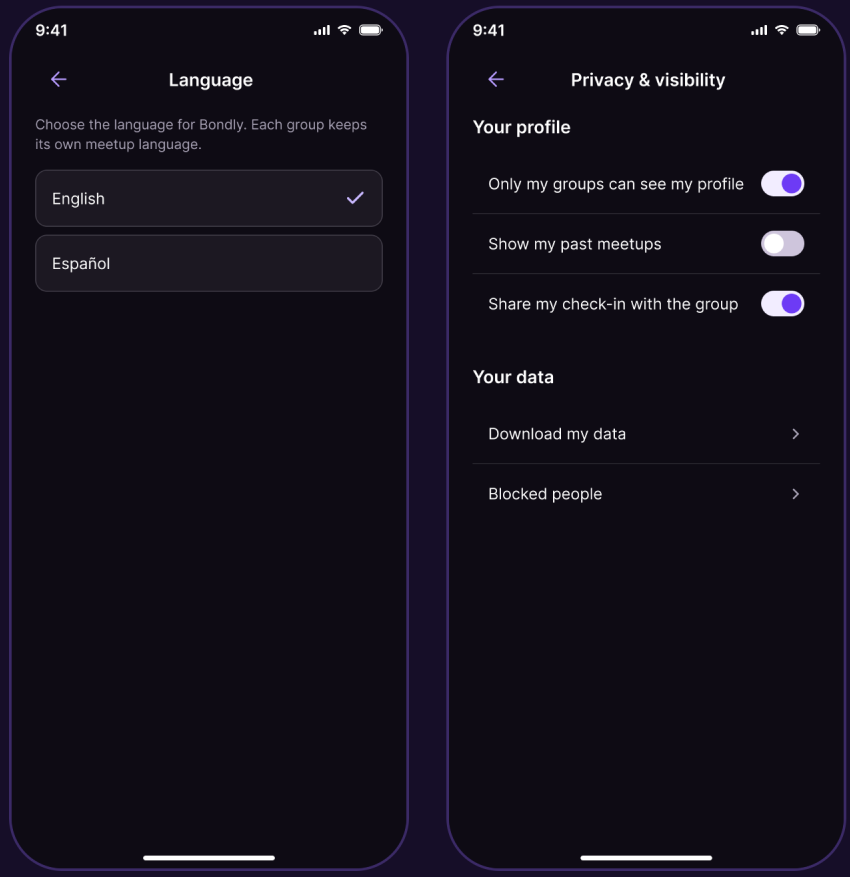
- Clear rules from day one: public places only, and never one-on-one.
- Anonymous reports, with the emergency number shown first.
- Blocking explains exactly what changes, and the other person isn't told.



DESIGN · UNDER THE HOOD

A prototype that behaves like the app

- Variables hold the state: joining, cancelling or suggesting a meetup updates the screens that show it.
- Fully bilingual: one setting switches every string between English and Spanish, so testers use their own language.
- Permissions in context: location while exploring, notifications after joining a first meetup.
- A documented design system: tokens, type scale, components and usage rules.



VALIDATION · USABILITY TEST, ROUND 1

4 of 5 participants completed the journey

Saying you're running late

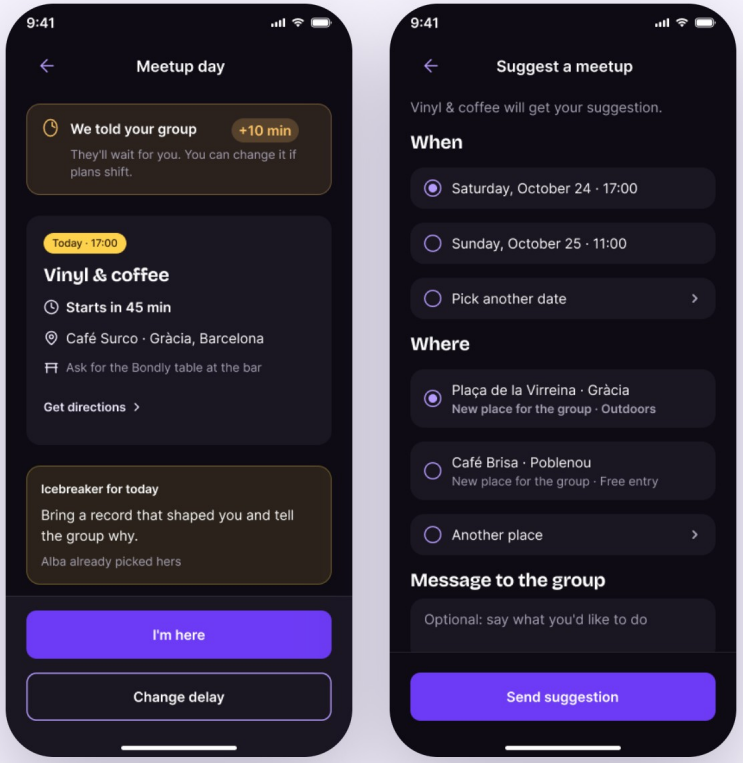
Observed: the sheet closed with no feedback, so it wasn't clear the group had been told.

Fix: a confirmation with the delay, your status in the arrivals list and a "Change delay" button.

Suggesting the next meetup

Observed: the date and place options didn't respond, so the plan couldn't be changed.

Fix: selectable dates and places, and the sent suggestion shows the choice.



5 participants · moderated remote sessions on Google Meet · clickable Figma prototype

REFLECTION · WHAT I LEARNED

What I'd take into the next project

Let research move the problem

I started from meeting someone new. The interviews showed the real drop-off is showing up, and then meeting again.

Fidelity is part of the test

Both round-1 issues were screens that didn't respond. A dead tap reads as a design flaw, so every path has to work before testing.

VALIDATION · WHAT'S NEXT

Re-test the fixes, then pilot the group rules

VALIDATION PLAN

Usability test, round 2: re-test running late and suggesting a meetup with three new participants.

Small pilot: compare sign-ups with real attendance, and track second meetups.

Success criteria defined before the pilot.

STILL OPEN

Groups of six and the three-person rule.

What "free" means for cafés.

Who welcomes the group on arrival.